BeezKnees

STRONGER HIVES, BETTER BEEKEEPING

APRIL

BEEKEEPING GUIDE (UK)

INSPECTIONS, SWARM CONTROL & SUPERS



April is where the beekeeping season gathers pace in the UK. Colonies expand, brood nests grow and nectar flows increase. Regular inspections, space management and swarm control preparation are key to strong, healthy colonies.

BEE BEHAVIOUR

- Brood nest expanding rapidly
- Foraging increases on warmer days
- Drone brood appears
- Population rising fast

KEY JOBS

- Inspect every 7–10 days
- Check brood, queen and food stores
- Add supers when needed
- Prepare for swarm control

RISKS TO WATCH

- Starvation during cold snaps
- Early swarm preparation
- Chilling brood with long inspections
- Colonies becoming overcrowded

1. CHECKING FOOD STORES



- Heft hives and compare weight with earlier visits.
- Ensure sealed stores remain close to the brood.
- Feed if light – fondant in cold spells or syrup when weather is warmer.

2. SPRING INSPECTIONS

- Confirm the colony is queenright (eggs/young larvae).
- Check brood pattern – healthy and well covered.
- Ensure enough space in brood box.
- Look for queen cups or charged queen cells.
- Check for disease or pests.



3. SWARM CONTROL PREPARATION



- Understand your swarm prevention method.
- Ensure enough brood space – avoid congestion.
- Have spare equipment ready for splits or artificial swarms.
- Identify high-risk colonies and monitor closely.

4. ADDING SUPERS

- Add a super when bees are working most frames.
- Use drawn comb if possible.
- Don't wait until the hive is congested.
- Record when supers are added and how quickly they fill.



5. DISEASE & VARROA AWARENESS



- Watch for signs of disease or pests.
- Monitor varroa levels using suitable methods.
- Keep treatment records up to date.
- Weaker colonies – investigate early.

6. HYGIENE & EQUIPMENT

- Clean and scorch boxes, floors and frames.
- Replace old, damaged or mouldy frames.
- Check stands, entrances and water sources.
- Plan gradual comb replacement.



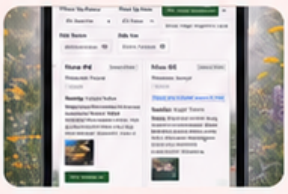
7. FORAGE & POLLINATORS



- Spring sources include dandelion, fruit blossom, willow and oilseed rape.
- Let flowers bloom – delay cutting where possible.
- Avoid pesticides on bee-friendly plants.

8. RECORD KEEPING & LEARNING

- Record inspections, brood, queen, food and actions.
- Note queen cells, swarm signs and splits.
- Use tools like HiveTag to track and compare.
- Keep learning – read, ask and improve.



APRIL TIMELINE – WHAT TO DO & WHEN

Inspect every 7–10 days, check food, watch for queen cells, add supers when needed and prepare for swarm control. Good records now lead to better decisions all season.